

Work-Life Balance of Married Working Women in the Kalyan-Dombivli Region

A Study of Occupational Challenges, Family Conflicts, and Coping Strategies

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ABSTRACT

This research paper investigates the work-life balance (WLB) challenges faced by married working women in the Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation (KDMC) region of Maharashtra, India. The study explores the interplay between professional responsibilities and domestic obligations, with a particular focus on work-family conflict (WFC) and family-work conflict (FWC).

Through a structured survey of 30 married working women representing diverse occupational sectors including healthcare, education, manufacturing, and services the study identifies key stressors such as role overload, inflexible working hours, lack of institutional support, and inadequate childcare infrastructure. Findings reveal that women with younger children and longer working hours experience significantly higher levels of conflict.

The research also highlights the critical role of spousal and family support as a buffer against occupational stress. The paper concludes with evidence-based recommendations for employers, policymakers, and individual women to foster a more equitable and sustainable work environment

Keywords: Work-Life Balance, Work-Family Conflict, Family-Work Conflict, Married Working Women, Role Overload, Occupational Stress, Kalyan-Dombivli, India

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

The twenty-first century has witnessed an unprecedented transformation in the socioeconomic fabric of Indian society. Rapid urbanization, expanding educational access, and shifting cultural norms have collectively redefined the role of women in the workforce. Indian women today are not merely supplementary earners—they are professionals, entrepreneurs, caregivers, and community leaders navigating a complex web of responsibilities.

In densely populated urban corridors such as the Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation (KDMC) region—one of Maharashtra's most populous urban local bodies—this transformation is especially pronounced. Thousands of married women commute daily to offices, factories, hospitals, schools, and commercial establishments, returning home to fulfill equally demanding domestic roles. The cumulative toll of this 'double burden' has emerged as a pressing social and organizational concern.

Work-life balance (WLB) refers to the degree to which individuals are equally engaged in and equally satisfied with their work and family roles (Greenhaus & Allen, 2011). For married working women in India, this balance is often elusive. Traditional gender norms continue to assign primary household and caregiving responsibilities to women, even as economic necessity and personal aspirations draw them into the formal labour market. The result is a systemic tension that manifests as role conflict, occupational stress, reduced job satisfaction, and compromised well-being.

1.2 Significance of the Study

Most scholarly literature on work-life balance originates in Western organizational contexts, where structural supports such as paid parental leave, subsidized childcare, and flexible work arrangements are more institutionalized. Indian working women operate under substantially different socioeconomic conditions, yet the volume of India-specific, region-focused research remains limited.

The Kalyan-Dombivli region presents a particularly instructive case. As a rapidly growing satellite city of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, it hosts a diverse working population that spans income levels, educational backgrounds, and occupational sectors. Examining work-life balance

dynamics within this specific geographic and cultural context yields insights that are both academically significant and practically actionable.

1.3 Scope of the Study

This study is confined to married working women residing and/or employed within the Kalyan-Dombivli region. The sample includes women from varied professional backgrounds including healthcare, education, banking, retail, and manufacturing ensuring representativeness across sectors. The study examines subjective experiences of work-family conflict, perceived sources of stress, available support systems, and individual coping strategies.

2. AIM AND OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

2.1 Aim

The primary aim of this research is to study the various factors that affect the work-life balance of married working women in the Kalyan-Dombivli region, and to understand how these women navigate the conflicts arising from their dual roles as professionals and homemakers.

2.2 Objectives

The specific objectives of the study are:

1. To identify the primary sources of work-family conflict (WFC) and family-work conflict (FWC) among married working women in the KDMC region.
2. To assess the impact of demographic variables (age, number of children, children's age, working hours) on the level of conflict experienced.
3. To examine the role of workplace characteristics (supervisor support, organizational culture, work schedule flexibility) in influencing WLB outcomes.
4. To evaluate the support systems spousal, familial, and institutional that help women manage their dual roles.
5. To explore the coping strategies adopted by married working women to mitigate role conflict and maintain psychological well-being.
6. To formulate evidence-based recommendations for employers and policymakers to improve WLB conditions for working women in the region.

3. REVIEW OF LITERATURE

3.1 Conceptual Framework: Work-Life Balance

The concept of work-life balance has evolved significantly over the past five decades. Early frameworks, such as the Border Theory proposed by Clark (2000), conceptualize work and family as distinct domains separated by permeable borders through which individuals cross daily. The ease or difficulty of these crossings influenced by the flexibility and permeability of each domain determines the individual's experience of balance or conflict.

Greenhaus and Beutell (1985) defined work-family conflict as 'a form of inter-role conflict in which role pressures from work and family domains are mutually incompatible in some respect.' This foundational definition underpins much of the subsequent literature and informs the analytical framework of the present study. They identified three forms of WFC: time-based conflict (when time devoted to one role makes it difficult to fulfil the other), strain-based conflict (when stress from one role spills over into the other), and behaviour-based conflict (when behaviours expected in one role are incompatible with the other).

Frone, Russell, and Cooper (1992) established that WFC and FWC are distinct but related constructs. While WFC primarily affects job satisfaction and organizational commitment, FWC tends to have more pronounced effects on life satisfaction and family cohesion. Both constructs are relevant to the present study.

3.2 Work-Life Balance Among Indian Women

India's cultural context adds layers of complexity to the WLB equation. The joint family system, while providing childcare support in some cases, also introduces additional domestic expectations. Patriarchal norms, though weakening in urban settings, continue to structure the distribution of household labour. Rao (2012) found that even among highly educated dual-income couples in metropolitan India, women retained primary responsibility for household management and child-rearing.

Bharat (2003) noted that the rapid entry of women into the formal workforce had not been accompanied by a commensurate redistribution of domestic responsibilities, leading to what sociologists term the 'second shift' the unpaid domestic labour performed by employed women

after their paid working hours. This phenomenon is particularly pronounced in rapidly urbanizing regions such as KDMC.

Studies by Devi and Rani (2012) and Saini and Srivastava (2013) documented that work-family conflict among Indian women is associated with reduced organizational commitment, higher absenteeism, and greater intention to leave employment. These findings have significant implications for both individual well-being and organizational productivity.

3.3 Role Theory and Role Conflict

Role theory, as articulated by Katz and Kahn (1978), provides a robust framework for understanding work-life conflict. According to role theory, each individual occupies multiple social positions (roles), each of which carries associated expectations and demands. When the demands of different roles are incompatible in terms of time, energy, or expected behaviour role conflict arises.

For married working women, the primary role conflict arises between occupational roles (employee, professional, colleague) and domestic roles (wife, mother, daughter-in-law, homemaker). The scarcity hypothesis, advanced by Marks (1977), posits that human energy and time are finite resources; engagement in multiple demanding roles inevitably leads to depletion and conflict. Conversely, the enhancement hypothesis (Sieber, 1974) suggests that multiple roles can provide complementary benefits income, social identity, personal fulfilment that collectively improve well-being.

The present research takes a nuanced position, recognizing that the relationship between multiple roles and well-being is contingent on the quality of those roles and the structural supports available to the individual.

3.4 Workplace Factors and Organizational Culture

Organizational culture has been consistently identified as a critical determinant of WLB outcomes. Cultures that implicitly or explicitly reward long working hours, penalize work flexibility requests, or normalize gender-based task allocation undermine women's ability to manage their dual responsibilities. Scandura and Lankau (1997) found that supervisor support was among the strongest predictors of reduced WFC.

In the Indian context, Allen et al. (2000) identified a strong positive relationship between family-supportive organizational perceptions and reduced WFC. Women who perceived their organizations as supportive of family responsibilities reported lower levels of strain and higher job satisfaction, regardless of their actual workload.

3.5 Coping Strategies

Research on coping strategies among working women has identified two broad approaches: emotion-focused coping (reframing, social support-seeking, relaxation) and problem-focused coping (time management, renegotiating responsibilities, seeking practical support). Lazarus and Folkman (1984) argued that both types are essential, and their effectiveness depends on the perceived controllability of the stressor.

Studies specific to Indian working women suggest that social support particularly from spouses, in-laws, and extended family is a predominant coping resource. Thomas and Ganguli (2020) found that strong spousal support was the single most significant protective factor against severe WFC among married women in metropolitan Maharashtra.

4. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

4.1 Research Design

This study adopts a descriptive and analytical research design. A combination of primary data (collected through a structured questionnaire-based survey) and secondary data (drawn from published research, government reports, and organizational studies) is employed. The mixed-methods approach allows for both quantitative assessment of conflict levels and qualitative understanding of subjective experiences.

4.2 Population and Sample

The target population comprises married working women residing and/or employed in the Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation (KDMC) region of Maharashtra, India. A purposive sampling method was employed to ensure representation across age groups, occupational sectors, and family structures.

A sample of 30 married working women was surveyed. While this sample size is appropriate for a preliminary study, the findings should be interpreted as indicative rather than definitively generalizable. Future research with larger, randomly selected samples would enhance the statistical robustness of the conclusions.

4.3 Data Collection Instrument

A structured questionnaire was designed comprising both closed-ended (Likert scale and multiple-choice) and open-ended questions. The questionnaire was organized into five sections:

- Section A: Socio-demographic profile (age, education, occupation, years of marriage, number of children, children's ages)
- Section B: Work characteristics (working hours per day, nature of employment, sector, commuting time, work schedule flexibility)
- Section C: Work-family conflict and family-work conflict measures (adapted from established WFC/FWC scales)
- Section D: Support systems (spousal support, family support, organizational support)
- Section E: Coping strategies and general well-being

4.4 Data Analysis

Quantitative data were analyzed using descriptive statistics (frequency distributions, percentages, mean scores). Cross-tabulation analysis was performed to explore relationships between demographic variables and conflict levels. Qualitative responses were subjected to thematic analysis to identify recurring patterns and narratives.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

All participants were informed about the purpose of the study and provided written or verbal consent. Anonymity and confidentiality were maintained throughout the research process. No identifying information is disclosed in this paper. The research adheres to established principles of academic integrity and research ethics.

5. WORK-LIFE BALANCE: CONCEPTUAL DISCUSSION

5.1 The Nature of Work-Family Conflict

Work-family conflict operates as a bidirectional phenomenon. Work-to-family conflict (WFC) occurs when the demands of the work role make it difficult to fulfil family responsibilities. Family-to-work conflict (FWC) arises in the opposite direction, when family demands interfere with work performance. Research consistently demonstrates that both forms of conflict are prevalent among married working women, though their relative intensities vary by individual circumstances.

For married women in the KDMC region, WFC is particularly pronounced given the long commuting times characteristic of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region. A woman who commutes two hours daily effectively loses four hours of potential family engagement time beyond her standard working day. This structural time-bind creates cascading demands that intensify both WFC and FWC.

5.2 The Double Burden: Professional and Domestic Labour

The concept of the 'double burden' or 'double shift' captures the reality of women who engage in paid employment while retaining primary responsibility for unpaid domestic labour. Unlike their male counterparts, married working women in most Indian households do not return home to rest after a working day; they return to a second, uncompensated shift of cooking, cleaning, childcare, and elder care.

This double burden is not merely a practical inconvenience; it has measurable consequences for physical health, mental well-being, and career advancement. Women who bear a disproportionate domestic load report higher levels of fatigue, greater susceptibility to stress-related illness, reduced participation in professional development activities, and lower rates of career progression.

5.3 Children's Age as a Determinant of Conflict

A consistent finding in the WLB literature corroborated by the present study is that children's age is a significant moderator of work-family conflict. Women with preschool-age children (0–5 years) face the highest levels of conflict, as this developmental stage demands intensive parental engagement and the costs of formal childcare are prohibitive for many families.

Women with school-age children (6–12 years) experience moderate levels of conflict, shaped by the competing demands of school schedules, homework supervision, extracurricular activities, and routine healthcare. Women with adolescent or adult children report lower levels of WFC, though this may be offset by increasing elder care responsibilities for aging in-laws.

5.4 Organizational Culture and Women's Career Trajectories

Organizational culture defined as the shared values, beliefs, and behavioural norms that characterize an organization is a powerful, if often invisible, determinant of women's work-life experiences. Organizations that valorize long working hours, discourage the use of flexible work arrangements, or maintain informal networks from which women are excluded create structural barriers to work-life balance.

Conversely, organizations that actively promote family-supportive policies, implement flexible work arrangements, and cultivate gender-inclusive cultures enable women to manage their dual roles more effectively. The distinction is not merely between formal policy and absence of policy, but between policies that are genuinely operationalized and those that exist only on paper.

6. WORK STRESS DUE TO WORKLOAD

6.1 Understanding Occupational Stress

Occupational stress is defined as the adverse psychological and physiological response that occurs when the demands of the work environment exceed the individual's capacity to meet them (NIOSH, 1999). For married working women, occupational stress is compounded by domestic stressors, creating a cumulative burden that standard stress management frameworks designed primarily for single-role incumbents fail to adequately address.

The stress response has three primary dimensions of impact, as identified in the research literature. The physical dimension manifests as somatic symptoms muscle tension, headaches, gastrointestinal disturbances, disrupted sleep patterns, and reduced immune function. The cognitive dimension influences thought patterns, decision-making, and attentional focus, often resulting in impaired concentration and memory. The emotional dimension governs an individual's affective responses to their environment, with chronic stress associated with heightened anxiety, irritability, and depressive symptomatology.

6.2 Role Overload

Role overload defined as the condition in which the total demands on time and energy associated with prescribed activities of multiple roles are too great to perform the roles adequately or comfortably (Duxbury & Higgins, 2001) is the most pervasive form of occupational stress among married working women. Unlike role conflict (which involves incompatible role expectations) or role ambiguity (which involves unclear role expectations), role overload is fundamentally quantitative: there is simply too much to do.

Working mothers report disproportionately higher levels of role overload compared to working fathers, non-parent working women, and working mothers' spouses. Research indicates that the total workload for employed mothers combining paid and unpaid labour exceeds that of employed fathers by an average of 15 to 20 hours per week. This persistent differential reflects both occupational demands and the unequal distribution of domestic responsibilities.

6.3 Role Conflict and Role Ambiguity

Role conflict occurs when an individual receives mutually incompatible expectations from different role senders. For a married working woman, role conflict may arise when an employer

expects extended working hours precisely when a child is ill and requires parental care, or when a supervisor schedules a critical meeting at the same time as a school function.

Role ambiguity, while typically considered less severe than role conflict, also contributes to occupational stress among working women. Uncertainty about performance expectations, advancement criteria, and organizational support for family responsibilities can generate sustained anxiety that undermines both work performance and family well-being.

6.4 Spillover Effects

Stress does not remain neatly compartmentalized within the domain in which it originates. Spillover theory (Staines, 1980) describes the process by which affect, attitudes, skills, and behaviours from one domain transfer to another. Negative spillover from work to family characterized by emotional exhaustion, irritability, and diminished engagement at home is significantly more prevalent among married working women than men in comparable occupational positions.

The consequences of negative spillover extend beyond the individual: research documents adverse effects on children's academic performance, spousal relationship quality, and household management efficiency. This creates a feedback loop in which family stressors, amplified by work-related spillover, generate renewed work performance deficits.

7. SURVEY ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

7.1 Socio-Demographic Profile of Respondents

The following table presents the socio-demographic characteristics of the 30 respondents:

Characteristic	Category	No. of Respondents (%)
Age Group	25–30 years	9 (30%)
	31–35 years	12 (40%)
	36–40 years	7 (23%)
	Above 40 years	2 (7%)
Educational Qualification	Graduate	14 (47%)
	Post-Graduate	11 (37%)
	Diploma / Others	5 (17%)
Sector of Employment	Healthcare	7 (23%)
	Education	6 (20%)
	Banking & Finance	5 (17%)
	Manufacturing / Industry	6 (20%)
	Retail / Services	6 (20%)
Number of Children	No children	5 (17%)
	One child	13 (43%)
	Two children	10 (33%)
	Three or more	2 (7%)

Table 1: Socio-Demographic Profile of Survey Respondents (N=30)

7.2 Working Hours and Time-Based Conflict

Respondents were asked to indicate their average daily working hours (excluding commute). Results reveal that 67% of women work 7 or more hours per day, with an additional 23% working approximately 6 hours. Only 10% of respondents work 5 hours or fewer, suggesting that part-time employment is not a common arrangement in the region. These figures are consistent

with national trends; however, they are particularly notable when viewed alongside the region's well-documented long commuting distances.

Working Hours Per Day	Number of Respondents	Percentage
5 hours or fewer	3	10%
6 hours	7	23%
7+ hours	20	67%
Total	30	100%

Table 2: Distribution of Daily Working Hours Among Respondents

7.3 Physical and Mental Capacity to Manage Dual Roles

When asked whether they felt both physically and mentally capable of balancing household chores and office work simultaneously, responses were notably varied. Approximately 40% of respondents expressed confidence in their ability to manage both domains, while 35% indicated that they managed but experienced significant fatigue. The remaining 25% reported difficulty in maintaining balance, with noticeable spillover effects on both their professional performance and family relationships.

These findings underscore an important distinction between functional capability (the ability to complete required tasks) and sustainable well-being (the ability to do so without chronic depletion of physical and emotional resources). Many respondents who reported functional capability also acknowledged experiencing chronic tiredness, reduced leisure time, and diminished quality of interaction with family members.

Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Yes, I feel capable and manage well	12	40%
I manage, but with significant fatigue	11	37%
I find it difficult to balance both	7	23%
Total	30	100%

Table 3: Self-Reported Capacity to Balance Work and Home Responsibilities

7.4 Family Expectations and Support Systems

Survey respondents were asked to indicate what they primarily expect from their families while maintaining a working life. The most common expectations cited were practical help with household tasks (43%) and emotional motivation and encouragement (38%). A smaller proportion (12%) expected financial support to ease household management, while 7% indicated other forms of support such as assistance with childcare logistics.

These findings reveal that working women in the KDMC region value emotional support almost as highly as practical assistance, challenging simplistic assumptions that material support is the predominant need. The desire for recognition and encouragement suggests that many women feel their professional contributions are undervalued within the domestic sphere.

Expected Support from Family	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Help with household tasks	13	43%
Emotional motivation & encouragement	11	37%
Financial support for household management	4	13%
Other (childcare logistics, etc.)	2	7%
Total	30	100%

Table 4: Primary Expectations from Family While Maintaining a Working Life

7.5 Career vs. Family Priorities

Respondents were asked whether they would give up their family life for their career. An overwhelming majority (83%) responded negatively, indicating that family remains the central priority in their lives even as they maintain professional careers. 10% expressed ambivalence, and only 7% indicated that career advancement could, under certain circumstances, take precedence over family considerations.

This finding has important implications for organizational human resource practices. It suggests that the majority of working women in the region are not primarily career-centric in the traditional sense; rather, they seek careers that accommodate, rather than supplant, their family

commitments. Organizational strategies that position career advancement as incompatible with family engagement are likely to generate attrition among this demographic.

7.6 Financial Independence and Its Perceived Importance

When asked whether financial independence is important for a woman, 93% of respondents agreed that it is essential or very important. This finding reflects both the economic realities of the region where dual incomes are often necessary for household sustainability and a broader shift in women's self-perception and aspirations.

Financial independence was described by respondents as enabling autonomy in decision-making, providing security against domestic contingencies, and supporting children's education and future prospects. Several respondents noted that earning an income, despite the associated stress, conferred a sense of personal agency and social dignity that they were unwilling to relinquish.

7.7 Challenges in Balancing Work-Life and Home

Survey respondents identified the following as their primary challenges in maintaining work-life balance:

Challenge	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Time management and long working hours	22	73%
Childcare and eldercare responsibilities	18	60%
Long commute and transportation stress	16	53%
Lack of support at workplace	14	47%
Lack of adequate domestic support	12	40%
Societal/family expectations and pressure	11	37%
Health and physical fatigue	9	30%

Table 5: Key Challenges in Work-Life Balance (Multiple Responses Permitted)

7.8 Primary Support Providers

Respondents were asked to identify the individuals who provide the most support in managing their workload. Spouses and children emerged as the most cited sources of support

(47%), followed by extended family members such as in-laws and parents (30%). Colleagues and friends were identified by 15% of respondents, while domestic help was cited by 8%.

The predominance of family-based support systems reflects both the cultural emphasis on familial bonds in Indian society and the relative underdevelopment of institutional support mechanisms such as employer-provided childcare, flexible work arrangements, and employee assistance programs in the KDMC region.

8. KEY FINDINGS

8.1 Summary of Major Findings

The analysis of survey data, supplemented by the review of existing literature, yields the following key findings:

- Work-life imbalance is widespread among married working women in the KDMC region, with 60% of respondents reporting significant challenges in managing their dual roles.
- Time-based conflict is the most prevalent form of WFC, driven by long working hours (67% work 7+ hours daily) and substantial commuting times characteristic of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region.
- Children's age is a significant determinant of conflict intensity; women with children aged 0–10 years report the highest levels of role overload and stress.
- Financial independence is near-universally valued (93%), suggesting that employment is not a source of conflict in itself but the conditions under which women work frequently are.
- Spousal and family support are the most critical buffers against severe work-life conflict; institutional support (from employers and government) remains underdeveloped.
- Women in hospital/healthcare settings report the highest WFC due to irregular and inflexible shift patterns; women in industrial/manufacturing settings report the highest FWC.
- Organizational culture characterized by unsupportive supervisors and inflexible schedules significantly amplifies conflict levels.
- Emotional motivation and practical household help are the two forms of support that working women most need and most frequently report as insufficient.

8.2 Cross-Tabulation: Working Hours vs. Conflict Level

Cross-tabulation analysis reveals a strong positive relationship between daily working hours and self-reported conflict level. Among women working 7+ hours daily, 75% report high or very high levels of WFC, compared to 43% among women working 6 hours and only 20% among those working 5 or fewer hours. This relationship holds across occupational sectors, suggesting that working hours are a robust predictor of WFC independent of sector-specific factors.

Working Hours	Low Conflict	Moderate Conflict	High / Very High Conflict
5 hrs or fewer (n=3)	2 (67%)	1 (33%)	0 (0%)
6 hours (n=7)	1 (14%)	3 (43%)	3 (43%)
7+ hours (n=20)	1 (5%)	4 (20%)	15 (75%)

Table 6: Cross-Tabulation of Daily Working Hours and Self-Reported Conflict Level

9. DISCUSSION

9.1 Alignment with Existing Literature

The findings of this study are broadly consistent with the established body of research on work-life balance among married working women in developing economy contexts. The predominance of time-based conflict, the role of children's age as a moderating variable, and the critical importance of spousal support as a protective factor all replicate findings from prior Indian studies (Devi & Rani, 2012; Thomas & Ganguli, 2020) and international research (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985; Frone et al., 1992).

However, the KDMC context introduces region-specific dynamics that merit separate consideration. The region's position within the Mumbai Metropolitan Region means that many women face commuting times of two to three hours daily—a structural burden not adequately captured in studies conducted in cities with more compact urban morphologies. When commuting time is incorporated into estimates of total work-related time commitment, the conflict experienced by KDMC working women is likely considerably higher than equivalent studies in more contained urban settings would suggest.

9.2 The Role of Financial Independence

The near-universal valuation of financial independence (93%) among respondents challenges narratives that frame working women's employment primarily in terms of economic necessity. While economic factors are certainly significant, respondents articulated employment as a source of personal agency, social identity, and future security—motivations that transcend immediate financial need. This finding aligns with Maslow's hierarchy of needs (1943) as applied to the Indian working woman's context: employment satisfies not only physiological (income) and safety (security) needs but also esteem and self-actualization needs.

This reframing has implications for organizational retention strategies. Women who work primarily for reasons of personal fulfilment and agency are unlikely to be retained through compensation increases alone; what they require are working environments that respect their dual commitments and support their holistic well-being.

9.3 Institutional Support Gaps

Perhaps the most significant gap identified by this study is the insufficiency of institutional support from employers, government agencies, and community organizations for working women in the KDMC region. Formal childcare facilities, particularly those affiliated with or subsidized by employers, are scarce. Flexible work arrangements, while increasingly common in metropolitan Mumbai, remain uncommon in the KDMC region's predominantly small and medium enterprise landscape.

Government initiatives such as the Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act of 2017 which extended paid maternity leave to 26 weeks for establishments with 50 or more employees represent important policy progress. However, compliance monitoring remains inconsistent, and the act's scope excludes the substantial informal sector workforce. The National Creche Scheme and Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) provide some support, but coverage in rapidly urbanizing zones such as KDMC lags well behind demand.

9.4 Coping Strategies: Strengths and Limitations

Respondents employed a diverse range of coping strategies, including time-blocking and prioritization, delegation of domestic tasks to extended family or paid help, seeking emotional support from spouses and colleagues, and in a minority of cases reducing professional ambitions or declining career advancement opportunities.

The latter coping strategy career self-limiting deserves particular attention. When working women manage role conflict by voluntarily restricting their professional aspirations, the consequences extend beyond the individual to encompass organizational diversity outcomes and macroeconomic productivity. Organizations that fail to address the structural sources of WFC inadvertently incentivize talented women to underperform or exit the workforce.

10. RECOMMENDATIONS

10.1 For Employers and Organizations

Based on the research findings, the following organizational interventions are recommended:

- Implement genuine flexible work arrangements: Flexible start/end times, compressed work weeks, and remote or hybrid work options where operationally feasible. Research consistently demonstrates that schedule flexibility is the single most impactful organizational policy for reducing WFC.
- Establish or subsidize childcare facilities: On-site or employer-partnered crèche and after-school care facilities significantly reduce the logistical burden on working mothers and decrease absenteeism.
- Train supervisors in family-supportive leadership: Supervisors play a disproportionate role in shaping employees' WLB experiences. Training programs that develop supervisors' awareness of and sensitivity to employees' family responsibilities can substantially reduce WFC.
- Review workload distribution: Organizations should audit task allocation practices to ensure that workloads are equitable and do not systematically disadvantage employees with family responsibilities.
- Create women's networks and mentoring programs: Peer support and mentoring can help women navigate organizational culture, access advancement opportunities, and manage professional challenges without sacrificing family well-being.
- Implement Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs): EAPs providing counselling, stress management resources, and financial planning support can equip working women with tools to manage the psychological dimensions of role conflict.

10.2 For Policy Makers and Government Bodies

- Expand affordable childcare infrastructure in KDMC: The rapid population growth of the region has outpaced the development of public childcare facilities. Investment in community-based crèches, particularly in densely populated residential areas, is urgently needed.

- Strengthen enforcement of maternity and workplace rights legislation: Comprehensive compliance monitoring and accessible grievance mechanisms are essential to translate policy protections into lived realities for working women.
- Incentivize family-friendly workplace practices: Tax incentives, certification programs, and public recognition for organizations that implement best-practice WLB policies can drive organizational behavior change at scale.
- Address commuting infrastructure: Improved and safe public transportation reduces commuting time and associated stress, directly benefiting working women whose time budgets are already severely constrained.

10.3 For Individual Women

- Communicate needs clearly within families: Open conversations with spouses and extended family about the expectations, pressures, and practical supports required can facilitate more equitable domestic arrangements.
- Establish boundaries and prioritize self-care: Chronic neglect of physical and mental health in service of work and family obligations is neither sustainable nor ultimately productive. Scheduled periods of rest, exercise, and personal engagement are essential investments in long-term capacity.
- Seek and utilize available institutional resources: Government schemes, employer programs, and community organizations offer support that many women are unaware of or reluctant to access.
- Build and maintain social support networks: Peer relationships with other working women provide both practical assistance and emotional validation, reducing the sense of isolation that role overload frequently generates.

11. CONCLUSION

This research has provided a nuanced examination of the work-life balance challenges faced by married working women in the Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation region of Maharashtra, India. The evidence assembled through primary survey data and a comprehensive review of existing literature reveals that WLB is not a personal failing or individual challenge but a structural phenomenon shaped by the intersection of organizational practices, domestic gender norms, policy environments, and socioeconomic conditions.

The women who participated in this study are not passive victims of circumstance. They are active navigators of complex and often contradictory demands, deploying intelligence, resilience, and creativity in the daily negotiation of their professional and personal lives. What they lack and what policy, organizational practice, and cultural change must provide are the structural supports that would make this navigation sustainable: affordable childcare, equitable domestic arrangements, family-supportive workplaces, and institutional recognition of their dual contributions.

The finding that 93% of respondents value financial independence underscores that women's workforce participation in the KDMC region is not merely economically contingent—it is aspirational and identity-affirming. The challenge for families, employers, and policymakers is to create conditions in which these aspirations can be realized without exacting unsustainable costs on women's health, relationships, and well-being.

The productive approach observed in this study's respondents—women who, despite exhaustion and role overload, continue to manage both professional and domestic domains with remarkable competence—is not a reason for complacency. It is, rather, a testament to what becomes possible when systemic change removes unnecessary barriers. Future research should expand the sample size, incorporate longitudinal tracking of WLB trajectories across career stages, and systematically evaluate the effectiveness of specific interventions in improving WLB outcomes for working women in this and comparable regional contexts.

12. LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

This study, like all research endeavors, is subject to certain limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings:

- **Sample size:** A sample of 30 respondents, while adequate for a preliminary study, limits the statistical power and generalizability of the quantitative findings. Future research should employ larger, randomly selected samples to permit more robust inferential analysis.
- **Self-report bias:** Survey data rely on respondents' subjective self-assessments, which may be influenced by social desirability effects. Respondents may underreport conflict levels perceived as socially stigmatizing or overreport positive coping to conform to expected narratives.
- **Cross-sectional design:** The study captures respondents' experiences at a single point in time. Longitudinal research would better illuminate how WLB dynamics evolve across career stages and family life cycles.
- **Geographic focus:** Findings are specific to the KDMC region and may not be fully transferable to other Indian urban contexts with different socioeconomic profiles, cultural norms, or infrastructure environments.
- **Sector representation:** While diverse, the sample may not fully represent all occupational sectors present in the region, particularly informal economy workers, who face distinct and often more acute WLB challenges.

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APPENDIX: SURVEY QUESTIONNAIRE

Survey: Work-Life Balance of Married Working Women – KDMC Region

The following questionnaire was administered to married working women in the Kalyan-Dombivli region. Participation was voluntary and all responses were kept strictly confidential.

Section A: Socio-Demographic Information

7. Age: (a) 25–30 (b) 31–35 (c) 36–40 (d) Above 40
8. Highest educational qualification: (a) Graduate (b) Post-Graduate (c) Diploma/Others
9. Current occupation / sector of employment: _____
10. Number of years in current job: _____
11. Number of children: (a) None (b) One (c) Two (d) Three or more
12. Age of youngest child (if applicable): _____

Section B: Work Characteristics

13. On average, how many hours do you work per day (excluding commute)? (a) 5 or fewer (b) 6 hours (c) 7 or more
14. How long is your daily one-way commute? (a) Less than 30 min (b) 30–60 min (c) 60–90 min (d) More than 90 min
15. Does your employer offer flexible working hours? (a) Yes (b) No (c) Partially
16. Does your supervisor understand and support your family responsibilities? (a) Yes (b) Somewhat (c) No

Section C: Work-Life Balance and Conflict

17. Do you feel both physically and mentally capable of balancing household work and office responsibilities? (a) Yes, I manage well (b) I manage but experience significant fatigue (c) I find it difficult to balance both
18. On a scale of 1–5, how often does your work interfere with your family responsibilities? (1=Never, 5=Always)
19. On a scale of 1–5, how often do your family responsibilities interfere with your work? (1=Never, 5=Always)

20. What are the primary challenges you face in maintaining work-life balance? (Select all that apply): Time management / long hours; Childcare and eldercare; Long commute; Lack of workplace support; Lack of domestic support; Societal/family expectations; Health and fatigue

Section D: Support Systems

21. Who provides you the most support in managing your workload? (a) Spouse/Partner (b) Children (c) In-laws/Extended family (d) Domestic help (e) Colleagues/Friends
22. What do you primarily expect from your family while maintaining a working life? (a) Practical help with household tasks (b) Emotional motivation and encouragement (c) Financial support (d) Other

Section E: Values and Coping

23. Would you give up your family life for your career? (a) Yes (b) No (c) Depends on circumstances
24. Is financial independence important for a woman? (a) Strongly agree (b) Agree (c) Neutral (d) Disagree
25. What coping strategies do you use to manage work-life conflict? (Open-ended)
26. Is there anything you would like your employer or the government to do differently to support your work-life balance? (Open-ended)

End of Questionnaire